We try Windows and macOS here, but the instructions for other operating systems follow the same pattern and are straightforward.

> **NOTE** We use a simple path of installing from a binary and running on a local machine, but it is usually handled differently in the real world. A separate team (DevOps, perhaps) may take ownership of installing and configuring the required setup and providing developers with preconfigured instances. The software can be on premises or in the cloud, depending on your organization's IT infrastructure strategy. Most cloud providers like AWS and Azure provide managed services. Elastic also has a managed cloud offering, which deploys the software in AWS, Azure, or Google Cloud.

Follow the instructions here to set up your personal development environment. Choose the right binary, and download it onto your computer. You can download it to any directory you choose. For example, I usually download software to the platform folder at <*my_home*>/DEV/platform for convenience. The current version of Elasticsearch is 8.6 as of writing this book, but be mindful that Elastic releases newer versions pretty quickly.

> **NOTE** The Elasticsearch binary is bundled with the Java JDK. This way, if you do not have Java installed (or it is not compatible), Elasticsearch does not moan about it; it goes about its business, referring to the packaged Java JDK. If you wish to install a non-bundled version, check out the download page, click the appropriate link that says non-JDK binary, and be sure `JAVA_HOME` is set and pointing to your local installation.

Now that you have downloaded the binary, the next step is to unpack the binary to install it on your local machine in your chosen folder. We discuss this in the next two sections for Windows and macOS operating systems: choose whichever section applies to your needs, and skip the other.

A.1.2 Starting up on Windows

After the file has downloaded successfully, uncompress the zip file to your installation folder. Table A.1 explains the folder structure Elasticsearch adheres to.

Table A.1 Elasticsearch folder structure

Folder name	Details
bin	The binary folder holding all the scripts to start the server as well as many other utilities. We usually don't need to touch the other executables, except the one to start the server: elasticsearch.bat (or .sh, depending on the OS).
config	Folder where the configuration for our server lives, especially the elasticsearch.yml file. Most properties are set for us so the server starts with sensible defaults.
plugins	A directory for hosting plugins—additional software modules that can be used to bring in new Elasticsearch features, such as creating a new text analyzer
modules	Contains modules